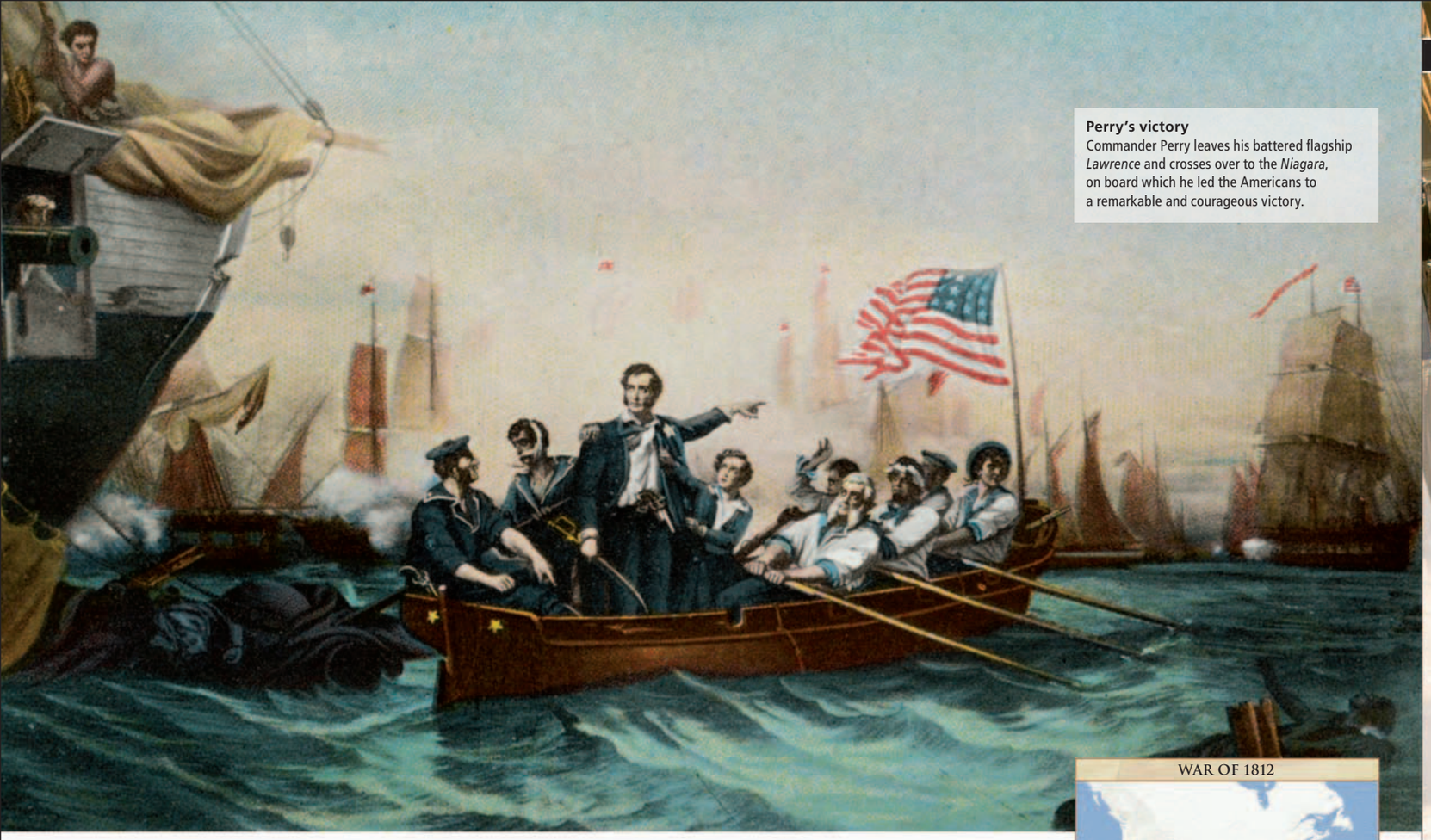


Perry's victory
Commander Perry leaves his battered flagship *Lawrence* and crosses over to the *Niagara*, on board which he led the Americans to a remarkable and courageous victory.

THE BATTLE OF LAKE ERIE

In March 1813, 27-year-old Master Commandant Oliver Hazard Perry arrived on the southern coast of Lake Erie, charged with creating a squadron of warships to win control of the lake from the British. Building ships and procuring guns and crews was a difficult task in such a remote region, but by the end of July Perry had two 20-gun square-rigged brigs, *Lawrence* and *Niagara*, supported by smaller vessels. The British, based at Amherstburg, experienced the same difficulties in building, equipping, and manning a lake fleet. Royal Navy commander Robert Barclay, a one-armed veteran of Trafalgar, had two ships that could take on Perry's brigs, the 19-gun *Detroit* and the 15-gun *Queen Charlotte*.

AMERICAN VICTORY

On the morning of September 10, the British came upon Perry's squadron in Put-in-Bay, in the lee of South Bass Island. Sailing out of the bay in line ahead, the Americans tacked for hours to gain the weather gage. Perry and Barclay both sought a conventional battle, in which each ship would place itself alongside an opponent of similar firepower and slug it out. However, for the Americans the approach went badly wrong. Perry placed his flagship *Lawrence* alongside Barclay's flagship *Detroit*, but Lieutenant Jesse Elliot on the *Niagara* failed to engage *Queen Charlotte*. Thus Perry soon found himself occupied with both of the largest British ships. The carnage on board *Lawrence* after two hours' close fighting was horrendous, although the American carronades visited similar punishment upon the British. With most of his gun carriages shattered and more than half his crew casualties, Perry decided to shift his flag. He had himself rowed across to the still unengaged *Niagara*, standing upright in the boat through heavy fire, while *Lawrence* struck its colors.

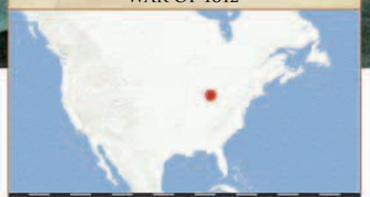


Spyglass telescope
Retractable to a portable size, telescopes such as these were vital to the functioning of a warship. By 1813 they had impressive magnification.

The British cheered the American flagship's surrender, but their joy was shortlived. Perry re-entered the fight with the fresh, undamaged *Niagara*. With most of his portside guns out of action, Barclay attempted to turn his ship to present the starboard broadside to the approaching American brig. For *Detroit* and *Queen Charlotte,* badly damaged and manned by mostly inexperienced crews now decimated by cannonfire, it was too complex a maneuver. The two ships ran into one another and became inextricably entangled. *Charlotte* had already lost her captain and first lieutenant; now Barclay was seriously wounded and his first lieutenant killed. Defenseless against *Niagara*'s broadsides, the two ships struck. The smaller British vessels either followed suit or were pursued and captured attempting to slip away.

The battle gave the Americans undisputed control of Lake Erie, and made a hero of Commander Perry.

WAR OF 1812



BATTLE OF LAKE ERIE

Date	September 10, 1813
Location	Lake Erie, Ohio
Result	American victory

COMBATANTS

UNITED STATES	BRITAIN

COMMANDERS

Oliver Hazard Perry	Robert Barclay

FORCES

Ships: 2 20-gun brigs, 7 other vessels	**Ships:** 2 ships, 2 brigs, 2 other vessels

LOSSES

Men: 27 dead, 96 wounded **Ships:** 1 brig damaged	**Men:** 41 killed, 306 captured, of which 93 wounded **Ships:** 6 captured

> "THE DECK WAS IN A SHOCKING PREDICAMENT ... THE DEAD WERE STREWED IN EVERY DIRECTION ... IT WAS IMPOSSIBLE TO TAKE THE WOUNDED BELOW AS FAST AS THEY FELL."
>
> **DAVID BUNNELL**, AMERICAN SAILOR , DESCRIBING THE SCENE ABOARD *LAWRENCE* IN HIS MEMOIRS